

A Reader's Guide to Thought, Freedom & Craft

"Friends often ask which books shaped me. These are the ones I keep going back to. Read with a pencil, keep what serves you, leave the rest."

Marc Duboc (@promaa), Seoul

Foundational Pillars & Liberty



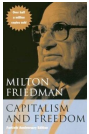
Man's Search for Meaning

Viktor E. Frankl (1946). Memoir · Resilience

Best for: When feeling overwhelmed or losing your sense of purpose.

Frankl survived Auschwitz and distilled the most liberating psychological truth ever written: you cannot always control your circumstances, but you always have absolute sovereignty over your attitude. Read when feeling adrift; trivial anxieties evaporate.

→ Finding a "why" that outlasts any collapse of the "how."



Capitalism and Freedom

Milton Friedman (1962). Essay · Economics & Liberty

Friedman cuts through bureaucratic rhetoric with razor clarity. Even without agreeing with every market conclusion, it forces you to question why we surrender so much daily autonomy to administrative inertia.

→ Economic freedom and personal autonomy are fundamentally inseparable.



On the Liberty of the Ancients compared with that of the Moderns

Benjamin Constant (1819). Speech / Essay · Political Theory

Constant drew a brilliant distinction: ancient freedom was constant political mobilization; modern freedom is the sacred right to be left in peace to pursue your craft, family, and ideas without interference.

→ The foundational case for private sanctuary over permanent political noise.



The Count of Monte Cristo

Alexandre Dumas (1844). Classic Novel · Strategy

The greatest adventure in literature, but really a masterclass in composure, patience, and playing the 20-year game. Edmond Dantès never panics; he calculates, accumulates leverage, and masters time.

→ "All human wisdom is contained in these two words: Wait and hope."



Discourse on Voluntary Servitude

Étienne de La Boétie (1576). Political Philosophy

Written by an 18-year-old in the 16th century, and still fresher than almost any modern commentary. His core insight is devastating: tyrants only hold power because the governed consent to obey them.

→ A short, electrifying shock to the system against passive compliance.

Systems, Power & Technology



Manufacturing Consent

Noam Chomsky & Edward S. Herman (1988). Media Theory · Systems

Breaks down the 5 structural filters through which mass media selects, frames, and purifies information. A diagnostic toolkit so you never consume news passively again.

→ Your personal mental firewall against manufactured consensus.



Permanent Record

Edward Snowden (2019). Memoir · Cybersecurity

Beyond NSA disclosures, this is about treating technology with ethical seriousness. Convenience is a trap: if you don't maintain your tools, your tools will control you.

→ Treat your machines and privacy with the rigor of a craftsman.

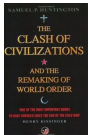


Atlas Shrugged

Ayn Rand (1957). Philosophical Fiction · Individualism

A monumental philosophical novel defending the primacy of reason, productive individual agency, and the creator's mind against bureaucratic collectivism and coerced guilt.

→ The mind is the prime mover of human progress; never sacrifice your agency to unearned guilt.



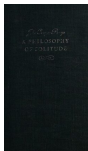
The Clash of Civilizations

Samuel P. Huntington (1996). Geopolitics · Macro-History

Predicted that post-Cold War conflicts would run along civilizational and cultural fault lines. An indispensable macro-lens to decode modern international flashpoints.

→ A pragmatic compass for navigating global geopolitical fractures.

Solitude, Discipline & Craft



A Philosophy of Solitude

John Cowper Powys (1933). Philosophy · Stillness

Best for: Sinking into sensory calm during hyper-connected burnout.

Practical rituals for cultivating an unshakeable inner fortress: elemental pauses, walking alone, observing wind and stone. Solitude here is the deliberate cultivation of one's own mind.

→ The antidote to hyper-connected overstimulation and mental burnout.



Vertigo of Dependence

Nathalie Sarthou-Lajus (2012). Essay · Relationships

A lucid reflection on the illusions of absolute self-sufficiency. Acknowledging our vulnerabilities and chosen bonds is the true starting point of emotional maturity.

→ A quiet mirror reminding us that true strength lies in accepting limits.

Great Narratives & The Human Condition



Crime and Punishment

Fyodor Dostoevsky (1866). Psychological Novel

Inside Raskolnikov's feverish brain as intellectual arrogance disintegrates against the crushing weight of human conscience. Unbearably tense and utterly profound.

→ The greatest warning against elevating abstract ideology over human reality.



Crépuscule

Juan Branco (2019). Investigative Pamphlet

Best for: Inspecting the revolving doors and inner circles of French power.

Whatever one thinks of Branco's polemical tone, the structural breakdown of Parisian oligarchic networks and revolving doors is documented with surgical precision.

→ A candid look inside the closed circles and machinery of French power.



A Liberal Named Jesus

Charles Gave (2019). Essay · Economics & Agency

An unorthodox, punchy read re-examining the Gospels through the lens of individual agency, capital allocation, and productive risk as moral duties.

→ A refreshing perspective on risk-taking, stewardship, and accountability.



The Story of Art

E. H. Gombrich (1950). Art History · Visual Culture

The antithesis of pretentious art theory. Gombrich writes like an attentive, wise friend strolling through an empty gallery, explaining how humanity learned to see light and perspective.

→ The single best companion book before visiting any museum in the world.



The Brothers Karamazov

Fyodor Dostoevsky (1880). Classic Novel · Philosophy

Dmitri (passion), Ivan (intellect), Alyosha (faith). Every fundamental conflict of human nature is played out in this family. The 'Grand Inquisitor' chapter alone is legendary.

→ The absolute pinnacle of psychological and philosophical literature.



The Gambler

Fyodor Dostoevsky (1867). Novella · Addiction

Written in just 26 days to pay off roulette debts, this short novel is a frantic dissection of how obsession and the illusion of control trap even sharp minds.

→ Fast, sharp, and brutally observant of the psychology of compulsive hope.



The Life Before Us

Romain Gary (Émile Ajar) (1975). Novel · Tenderness

Narrated by young Momo veiling over Madame Rosa in Belleville. It has more genuine warmth, human solidarity, and streetwise wisdom in 200 pages than entire literary eras.

→ A masterclass in humor, tenderness, and finding beauty in the margins.



Small Country

Gaël Faye (2016). Contemporary Novel

A luminous, heartbreaking story of childhood in Burundi shattered by war. Faye demonstrates how literature, music, and nature serve as the last shields of human dignity.

→ A poetic testament to memory and resilience in times of upheaval.



Promise at Dawn

Romain Gary (1960). Autobiographical Novel

Best for: Rekindling fierce filial love, courage, and literary panache.

Gary's tribute to his mother's boundless, irrational faith in him. It oscillates between laugh-out-loud humor and overwhelming emotional power.

→ The kind of book that makes you put it down and call your mother immediately.



Around the World in Eighty Days

Jules Verne (1872). Adventure · Stoicism

Read before hiking the GR20. Phileas Fogg's mathematical composure and Passepartout's loyalty make it the ultimate comfort read on resourcefulness and perseverance.

→ Pure Victorian rhythm, calm under pressure, and the joy of problem-solving.
